

Alabama Learning Workshop

Lesson 1: Getting Started!

September 17, 2026

1 Naaʔiilka *Dialogue*

Albaamo Innaaʔiilka

Alabama Language

① Meet Ava!

Holchifaya Ava.

Avaya aathomma imoolafon wiikahchi.

Himaakaya Albaama innaaʔiilkan sobaylihchi.

Mikkok Albaaamo innaaʔiilkan aabachihchi.

Himaakaya Avak bitlihchi.

Choffihchi.

Haatanahlichich.

Avak hoyaplihchi.

Chokoolihchi.

Pontokkolin oompahchi.

Nochihchi.

Her name is Ava.

Ava lives on the reservation.

Today, she is learning Alabama.

Mikko is teaching Alabama.

Now, Ava is dancing.

She is jumping.

She is spinning.

Ava is tired.

She is sitting down.

She is eating dinner.

She goes to sleep.

2 Vocabulary

Powwow-Related

holchifa	name
aathomma imoola	reservation
Albaamo/Albaama innaaʔiilka	Alabama language
pontokkoli	dinner
himaakaya	now

Verbs*

sobayli	to learn
aabachi	to teach
bitli	to dance
choffi	to jump (up and down; multiple times)
haatanahli	to spin (round and round; multiple times)
hoyapli	to be tired
chokooli	to sit down
nochi	to fall asleep
wiika	to live
chiyahli*	to walk
intohno*	to work
hompani	to play

Useful Phrases

ay*	yes
inkobi*	no
Chikaanõ?*	Hello! How are you?
Hachikaanõ?*	Hey y'all! How are y'all?
Chakaanobi*	I'm good.
Kokaanobi/Pokaanobi*	We're good.

*Words marked with an asterisk * appear in grammatical exercises but not the dialogue.

3 Grammar

3.1 Talking About Right Now

- In English, we sometimes need to add small pieces to verbs in order to tell when something is happening.

These are sometimes called morphemes by linguists.

(1) Tanya walks

- The same is true of Alabama. Below is the recipe for how to say something is happening *right now* in Alabama. We call this the **present tense**.
- In Alabama one way about talking about the present is to use the *-hchi* suffix. This tells us that we are in the process of doing something *right now!*.

In Alabama, like in English, there are many ways of saying the same thing, sometimes. Soon, we'll meet another suffix that can also be used to talk about the present tense: *-o/-bi*. So don't be surprised if you hear an elder say something that sounds a bit different sometimes!

Present Tense Verb Sentence Recipe I

[**Agent/Doer** + **Verb** + **-hchi**]

bitli 'dance'

- (2) a. Tom is dancing
b. Ava is dancing
c. My friend is dancing
(*amokla*)

- b. The bear (nita) is walking
c. Sally is walking

chiyahli 'walk'

- (3) a. Jacob is walking

hompani 'play'

- (4) a. The dog (ifa) is playing
b. Tanya is playing
c. The bear (nita) is playing

3.2 Sounds in Alabama: Learning Snotty Nose

- In Alabama, questions are asked in a certain voice, a **snotty nose intonation**.
- In Alabama, we indicate that we are asking a question by writing a ~ above the last letter of a question sentence.
- This includes the special word ending *-hchi* that we just learned about!

This is often called *nasalization* by linguists.

Present Tense Verb Question Recipe

[**Agent/Doer** + **Verb** + **-hchĩ?**]

Example:

(5) **Ava**-k **bitli**-**hchĩ?**

Ava dance-right.now?

‘Is Ava dancing?’

Now you try!

Complete the following dialogue by replacing [Verb] with one of the verbs of your choice below.

Q: Ava-**k** [**Verb**]-**hchĩ**?

A: Inkobi, Ava-**k** [**Verb**]-**hchi**

- choffi — to jump
- hinkahli — to wait
- ilichooyaasihli — to brush one's teeth
- intohno — to work
- chiyahli — to walk
- lawwi — to be loud

3.3 Case on Nouns

- In the example about you might notice that when we build a sentence there are these little pieces on the end of some words.

(6) Tany**ak** and Avan

- These pieces that appear on nouns are called *case*.
- Case tells us the role of the noun in the sentence: who is doing what to whom.
- The **k** tells us it is the **subject** of the sentence. For now, we can think of the subject as the noun which the sentence is

“about”.

- For example, the noun in agent verbs marked with this **k**.
 - *Avak bitliti* “Ava danced”, *anok chiyahliliti* “I walked”
- Case morphemes which indicate the subject, like **k**, are known as **nominative case**.

★ What about situations where there is more than one noun?

- When there is a subject and an object that is called a **transitive sentence**.
 - *I saw him, I helped you*
- If there is an **agent** who is *doing something* to another noun, then the agent is marked with **nominative case, k**.
- The noun that is being **affected** by the subject is marked with **oblique case, n**.

Let’s practice!

- | | | | |
|-----|---|------|--|
| (7) | a. ifa — dog
b. wohka — bark | (10) | a. hopooni — to cook
b. tayyi — woman
c. chassi — corn |
| (8) | a. hiicha — see
b. Jacob
c. Ava | (11) | a. mobilka — car
b. Tom
c. aabohli — wash |
| (9) | a. ɬaɬo — fish
b. foosi — bird
c. ipa — eat | (12) | a. nita — bear
b. choffi — rabbit
c. maatibi — hunt |

3.4 Sentence Order

- Different languages have different sentence order! In English we usually use

(13) **Subject** **Verb** **Object**

(14) **Tanya** **sees** **Ava**

- But in Alabama the words in a sentence are in a different order.

(15) **Subject** **Object** **Verb**

- So it might sound a little weird to say "Tanya sees Ava" and the sentence would be:

(16) **Tanya** **Ava** **sees**

(17) **Tanya-k** **Ava-n** **hiicha-hchi**